Draft for discussion

Benefits Modernisation Programme: independent assurance review, second review

Independent verification and validation report for the Programme Board

Department of Community Services Programme Board | 20 October 2026 | Independent Assurance Team

Confidential and proprietary. For internal discussion only.

Delivery confidence is amber overall: two of eight areas are red, and one finding is critical

Amber

Overall delivery confidence

Unchanged since the April 2026 review

2 of 8

Areas rated red

Suppliers, and data and architecture; 4 amber, 2 green

12

Findings

1 critical, **3** high, **5** medium, **3** low

4 of 9

April recommendations closed

2 are overdue

1. Scope: the full programme, including supplier delivery. Method: 31 interviews, 46 documents and a sample of test evidence. The assurance team has no delivery role and reports to the Audit Committee. Rating scale: Green means delivery is on course; Amber means delivery is achievable if named issues are fixed; Red means delivery is at risk without urgent action.

Source: Independent assurance team: 31 interviews and 46 documents, 8 September to 9 October 2026. Fictional example.

Supplier management and data migration are red and worsening, while risk management has improved

Ratings by area, October 2026

Compared with the April 2026 review

Area	Rating	Trend	Why
Governance and sponsorship	●	▶	Board meets monthly; decisions are logged and followed up
Business case and benefits	●	▼	£11m of the £42m yearly benefit depends on the delayed release 4
Schedule and delivery	●	▼	Release 3 is six weeks late; release 4 plan is untested
Cost and resourcing	●	▶	Forecast is 9% over budget; 14 of 60 posts vacant
Risk and issue management	●	▲	Register is current and risks have named owners
Suppliers and contracts	●	▼	Change requests average 41 days to agree; two suppliers disagree on scope
Data and architecture	●	▼	No tested plan to migrate 2.3 million customer records
Testing and release readiness	●	▲	Automated testing covers 68% of journeys, up from 40%

● On track ● At risk ● Off track ▲ Improving ▶ Stable ▼ Worsening

1. Rating scale as on the previous page. Trend compares with the April 2026 review: up means improved, down means worse.
Source: Independent assurance team: 31 interviews and 46 documents, 8 September to 9 October 2026. Fictional example.

Finding 1, critical: the plan to move 2.3 million customer records has never been tested end to end

Observation

- Two trial migrations used 4% of the records
- The full run has never been rehearsed
- No rollback plan exists if cutover fails
- Data quality owner is not named

Severity
Critical

Evidence
Migration trial reports

Impact

- Cutover in July 2027 could overrun its 48-hour window
- Customers could miss payments if records are wrong
- Failure would delay release 4 by about three months

Severity
Cutover at risk

Evidence
Release 4 plan

Recommendation

- Rehearse a full-volume migration by 28 February 2027
- Write and test a rollback plan by 31 March 2027
- Name a data quality owner by 6 November 2026
- Owner: Chief Data Officer

Severity
Due 28 Feb 2027

Evidence
Plan review, 12 Oct

Management response

- Accepted in full
- Rehearsal booked for 22 February 2027
- Rollback plan drafted; test date to be agreed
- Data owner named by 30 October

Severity
Accepted

Evidence
Response, 15 Oct

1. Severity: critical means the programme objective cannot be met without action; high means a milestone is at risk. Management response received 15 October 2026.
Source: Independent assurance team: 31 interviews and 46 documents, 8 September to 9 October 2026. Fictional example.

Finding 2, high: change requests take 41 days to agree because two suppliers disagree on scope

Observation

- Twenty-two change requests are open, with 41 days average age
- The platform and integration suppliers each read one interface as the other's job
- The contract sets 15 days for a decision

Severity

High

Evidence

Change log, 22 items

Impact

- Release 4 scope is not fixed
- Cost forecast is 9% over budget, partly through rework
- Supplier relations are strained

Severity

Scope not fixed

Evidence

Cost report, September

Recommendation

- Hold a joint scope workshop by 20 November 2026
- Set a 10-day limit for change decisions
- Escalate unresolved items to the SRO each fortnight
- Owner: Commercial Director

Severity

Due 20 Nov 2026

Evidence

Contract clause 14.2

Management response

- Accepted in part
- Agrees the workshop and the fortnightly escalation
- Keeps the 15-day contract limit until the contract is varied

Severity

Part accepted

Evidence

Response, 15 Oct

1. Severity: high means a milestone is at risk. Management response received 15 October 2026.

Source: Independent assurance team: 31 interviews and 46 documents, 8 September to 9 October 2026. Fictional example.

Four of nine recommendations from April are closed; the two overdue ones both concern suppliers

Progress on the nine recommendations from the April 2026 review

Status at 9 October 2026

Recommendation	Owner	Due	Status	Evidence
Appoint a full-time SRO	Permanent Secretary	Jun 26	On track	Appointed 1 June
Refresh the risk register monthly	Programme Director	May 26	On track	Six monthly refreshes
Fix scope of release 3	Programme Director	Jun 26	On track	Scope signed 12 June
Agree a benefits owner for each benefit	Business Lead	Jul 26	On track	Owners named for all 8 benefits
Publish an integrated release plan	Delivery Lead	Dec 26	At risk	Draft with the Board
Automate regression tests	Test Manager	Jan 27	At risk	68% coverage
Recruit 14 vacant posts	Resourcing Lead	Dec 26	At risk	Nine offers made
Agree a joint supplier governance forum	Commercial Director	Aug 26	Off track	Not yet met
Reset supplier performance measures	Commercial Director	Sep 26	Off track	Draft not agreed

On track At risk Off track

1. Status: Green = closed and evidenced; Amber = in progress and on time; Red = overdue.
Source: Independent assurance team: 31 interviews and 46 documents, 8 September to 9 October 2026. Fictional example.

The Board should fund the data rehearsal, settle the supplier scope dispute and review progress in January

#	Decision required	Recommendation and impact	Owner	By
1	**Fund a full-volume data migration rehearsal**	Approve £1.4m from contingency; the rehearsal runs by 28 February 2027	SRO	6 Nov
2	**Name a data quality owner and approve a tested rollback plan**	Chief Data Officer to own both; rollback test by 31 March 2027	Chief Data Officer	6 Nov
3	**Resolve the supplier scope dispute**	Joint workshop by 20 November; SRO decides any open points the same day	Commercial Director	20 Nov
4	**Schedule a follow-up check of the red areas**	Assurance team returns in January 2027 to check the two red areas	Programme Director	29 Jan

Source: Independent assurance team: 31 interviews and 46 documents, 8 September to 9 October 2026. Fictional example.